

mental health and wellbeing, risks wandering into the realms of judging consumers for their decisions rather than holding lenders accountable for their practice. What is deemed reasonable debt by some would be baulked at by others, in the same way that there will always be someone with different saving and spending priorities to you, and we need to be careful about acknowledging the line between equipping people with the information that they need and warning about predatory lenders, and further exacerbating the debt stigma that keeps so many people in a hole of guilt and shame. Largely, we are dealing with a trifecta of unfortunate truths about credit and debt: questionable ethics and motives on the part of some lenders, constant bombardment of credit opportunities everywhere from the sides of buses to the checkout on the ASOS website, and then the huge stigma around succumbing to any of these offers – especially if you find yourself in any kind of trouble. When you think about the impossible situation this leaves some people in, you begin to notice how broken it is that the system is essentially geared towards pressuring people to take on debt, then abandoning and chastising them if they struggle to manage it.

Having a healthy relationship with money, for many people, means being open to using credit and learning how to manage it well. The fear and stigma surrounding even small credit card balances can set any kind of non-mortgage debt up as a terrible, dirty secret, meaning that in situations where it's unavoidable, people enter a cycle of shame that can end up being very